



Deschutes River

The Deschutes River is a big river in Oregon. It helps carry water to the Columbia River. Long ago, Native Americans used the river to travel. Later, pioneers on the Oregon Trail used it too. The river goes through dry and rocky places. People like to fish and go rafting on the river in the summer. It also helps water the plants.

The river goes up, just like some other big rivers in Oregon, like the Willamette and John Day.

Course

The Deschutes River starts at Little Lava Lake. This lake is in the mountains. The river goes south to Crane Prairie Reservoir, then to Wickiup Reservoir. After that, it goes past Sunriver and into Bend. Bend is far from where the river ends.

In the middle of Bend, the river goes into Mirror Pond. This pond is behind a big dam. The pond goes all the way to the Galveston Bridge. It is part of Drake Park and some other parks too. From April to October, some water goes into special canals, making the river smaller between Bend and another dam far away.



The river as it passes Sunriver, near Benham Falls

The river goes north from Bend and near Redmond, Oregon. It goes by Eagle Crest Resort and Cline Falls. The river makes a big, deep path with tall rock walls.

Deschutes River



The Deschutes River near its mouth on the Columbia. Pioneers camped on the bluff to the left.



Figure 15. Location of surface-water and water-quality stations in the Deschutes River Basin.

Map of the Deschutes watershed

When it gets to Lake Billy Chinook, it is very low, like 300 feet down. At the lake, two more rivers, Crooked and Metolius, join it.

The river goes past the dam and keeps going north. It flows in a deep valley. It goes through a special place called the Warm Springs Indian Reservation. There is a city named Warm Springs and a fun place called Kah-Nee-Ta there. The river meets the big Columbia River. This happens 5 miles from a place called Biggs Junction and 204 miles from where the Columbia River goes into the ocean.

Tributaries

The Deschutes River has little rivers that join it. First, there's Snow Creek. Then come the Cultus River, Cultus Creek, and Deer Creek. They all meet at Crane Prairie Reservoir. Next, we have Fall River, Little Deschutes River, and Spring River. After that, Tumalo Creek and Whychus Creek join in.

The Metolius River and the Crooked River go into Lake Billy Chinook. Then come Seekseequa Creek and Willow Creek. Next are Dry Hollow, Campbell, Shitike, and Trout creeks. After that is the Warm Springs River. More down the river are Swamp, Skookum, Oak, Antoken, Cove, Eagle, Nena, Wapinitia, and Bakeoven creeks. Spring Creek comes next, then Oak Springs Creek and the White River. After that are Winterwater and Elder creeks.

History

A long, long time ago, the river went on the east side of a big hill called Pilot Butte. Then, hot lava came and filled up the old river path. Before that, another lava flow made the river move to where it is now.

The river was called Rivière des Chutes, which means River of the Falls. This was during the time when people traded fur. The name was about a waterfall called Celilo Falls. It was on the Columbia River, where the Deschutes River joined it. But now, the falls are gone because a big lake covered them up.



Location of the mouth of the Deschutes River in Oregon

- ☐ Show map of Oregon
- ☐ Show map of the United States
- ☐ Show all

Etymology From *Rivière des Chutes*, used by early-19th-century fur traders^[2]

Location

Country United States
State Oregon
County Deschutes, Jefferson, Sherman, and Wasco

Physical characteristics

Source Little Lava Lake

- location Cascade Range, Deschutes County, Oregon
- coordinates 43°54′33″N 121°45′40″W^[1]
- elevation 4,747 ft (1,447 m)^[3]

Mouth Columbia River

- location between Fairbanks and Biggs Junction, on border between Wasco and Sherman counties, Oregon
- coordinates 45°38′07″N 120°54′52″W^[1]
- elevation 164 ft (50 m)^[1]

Length 252 mi (406 km)^[4]

Basin size 10,500 sq mi (27,000 km²)^[5]

Discharge

- location Moody, 1.4 miles (2.3 km) from mouth^{[5][6]}
- average 5,824 cu ft/s (164.9 m³/s)^{[5][6]}
- minimum 2,400 cu ft/s (68 m³/s)

Lewis and Clark found a river on October 22, 1805. They called it Towarnehiooks, like the Native Americans did. Later, they named it Clarks River. Other names for the river are Clarks River, River of the Falls, Riviere des Chutes, Chutes River, and Falls River.

• maximum 70,300 cu ft/s (1,990 m³/s)

National Wild and Scenic River

Type Scenic, Recreational

Designated October 28, 1988

A long time ago, people traveled on the Oregon Trail. They had to cross a big river. The crossing spot was where the Deschutes River is now. After crossing, they camped on a hill. You can still see the old trail on the hill today.

A long time ago, in 1910, a big pond called Mirror Pond was made. It happened because people built a dam on the river in a place called Bend. This dam helped make electricity for the city. Now, a company named Pacific Power owns the dam. It still makes electricity for about 400 homes in Bend.

A long time ago, in 1908, two train companies wanted to build tracks to a place called Bend. One company was called Deschutes Railroad, and the other was Oregon Trunk Railway. They had a race to see who could build the tracks first!

In 1964, people built a big dam on the Deschutes River. It was the biggest in Oregon then. The dam is called Round Butte Dam. It is very tall, like 440 feet high. It makes a big lake called Lake Simtustus.

Fishing

The river is famous for fishing. It has special fish called "redsidés." These fish are bigger and have a dark red stripe. There are lots of them in the river. Above Sherar's Falls, there are many fish, and they are strong because the river is big and fast. People catch fish that are 8 to 15 inches long, and some are even bigger. You can find these fish all over the river. Fishing is popular from Warm Springs to Macks Canyon. You need special permits to fish on Tribal lands. The river is great for catching trout and summer steelhead. It goes through a deep canyon made of volcanic rock.



The Deschutes in winter at its confluence with the Columbia

People like to fish with special flies in the river. They come in May and June. Big bugs called stoneflies hatch then. Fish love to eat them. The bugs are there all year, but the big ones are special food. Fishermen use pretend bugs to catch fish all the time.

You can catch fish called Steelhead in the river from the start to Round Butte Dam. You can catch fish called Chinook salmon from the start to Sherars Falls. People from the tribe catch Chinook and Steelhead at Sherars Falls.

Crane Prairie Reservoir is a big lake where the Deschutes River goes. It has lots of big rainbow trout fish. Some are really big, like 4 to 10 pounds, and some are even 20 pounds! People call them "cranebows." Other fish there are brook trout, kokanee salmon, largemouth bass, black crappie, tui chub, three-spined stickleback, and whitefish. You can catch fish with a fly, lure, or bait. Most people use a boat to catch the big fish because the water is wide and deep.

Wickiup Reservoir is a big lake where people like to fish. It's not too far from another lake called Crane Prairie Reservoir. In Wickiup, you can catch lots of different fish like kokanee and Coho salmon. There are also rainbow trout, brook trout, whitefish, and chub. Many people try to catch big brown trout here. Some brown trout are really big, like as big as a small dog! Fishing from a boat is the best way because the water is deep. People use special fishing tricks like moving their fishing lines sideways or up and down to catch fish. If you like to fish from the shore, you can try to catch fish hiding in the shallow water.

In Lake Billy Chinook, you can find fish like kokanee, bull trout, rainbow trout, brown trout, and bass. There are lots of small mouth bass. People also catch crayfish sometimes. The bull trout here are really big! There aren't many because they need help, but more are coming back each year. You can keep a bull trout if it's bigger than 24 inches.

River use

In the summer, a lot of water from the Deschutes River goes into big ditches to help water farms. Almost all the river's water is used this way. Cities like Bend and Redmond need more water too. The ditches lose a lot of water because it seeps away, so some people want to change them into pipes. But many people don't like this idea because they like how the ditches look. There are also 13 golf courses that need water in Bend, Redmond, and Sunriver.

There are two parts of the river where people like to go rafting and kayaking. One part is called the Big Eddy. It's a little bit up the river from a place called Bend. The other part is from a town called Warm Springs down to a place near Sherars Falls. Lots of people like to go from a spot 4 miles above Maupin to just before Sherars Falls.

See also

- [List of longest streams of Oregon](#)
- [List of National Wild and Scenic Rivers](#)
- [List of rivers of Oregon](#)

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External links

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